

Organisational Behaviour & Assessment

Occupational psychology certification — theory paper (sample) · Sample Professional Board

EXAM DATE 2027-03-20	DAYS REMAINING D-224	TARGET SCORE 78
PASSING CRITERION 60% with no compensation between sections	SYLLABUS / VERSION Syllabus v4.2 (sample — verify current edition)	CURRENT CONFIDENCE 2/5

What does this exam actually test?

- Whether you can attribute a described scenario to the right theorist
- Whether you know what each theory does NOT claim
- Precise use of terms that share everyday meanings but differ technically
- Whether you can name the construct being measured, not just describe it

SUBJECTS • Motivation and engagement • Psychometrics • Leadership and teams	SOURCE MATERIALS • Board reading list, 3rd edition • Past papers 2020–2025
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The cycle



CORRECT is the load-bearing step. A wrong answer edits a named matrix cell, and that cell comes back in the next recall pass.

How to read a cell

Markers are encoded three ways — label, border, tint — so nothing is lost in grayscale.

Marker	Means	What to do with it
CORE	Baseline fact	Know it. Low retrieval priority.
◆ DIST	This is what separates the rows	Be able to state it in one clause.
▲ EXC	The rule does not hold here	Memorise the boundary, not the rule.
■ TRAP	Examiners build wrong answers from this	Rehearse the wrong version and why it is wrong.
⌚ UPD	Version-sensitive — verify the date	Re-check against the current text before the exam.
§ EVD	Wording or source, quoted	Recognise the phrasing on sight.

Exam Blueprint

Organisational Behaviour & Assessment

Domain	Weight	Question type	Priority	Current confidence	Last review
Motivation theory	30%	Scenario-based multiple choice	A	●●○○○ 2/5	2026-08-05
Psychometrics	30%	Multiple choice + short answer	A	●●○○○ 2/5	2026-08-06
Leadership	25%	Scenario-based multiple choice	B	●●●○○ 3/5	2026-07-19
Research ethics	15%	Multiple choice	C	●●●●○ 4/5	2026-07-02

HIGH-YIELD TOPICS - Herzberg's two-factor asymmetry - Reliability vs validity	WEAK TOPICS - Distinguishing Vroom's three components - Construct vs criterion validity	VOLATILE / VERSION-SENSITIVE Ethical guidance is reissued periodically — check the current edition
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Topic index

#	Topic	Archetype	Priority	Rows
01	Content and process theories of motivation What the theory claims motivation is made of	Concept / Theory	A	6
02	Reliability and validity Consistency vs correctness	Concept / Theory	A	6

Content and process theories of motivation

Key comparison axis: What the theory claims motivation is made of

WHY IT MATTERS

The paper describes a workplace scenario and asks which theory explains it. Every distractor is a real theory applied to the wrong cue.

CORE QUESTION

Which theory does this scenario's specific cue point to?

PREREQUISITES Intrinsic vs extrinsic motivation **SOURCE** Reading list ch. 4

One-sentence model

Explain this topic in ONE sentence, as if to someone sitting the exam tomorrow. If you cannot, you do not know it yet.

Content theories say motivation comes from which needs are unmet, while process theories say it comes from how people reason about effort, reward and fairness.

Five essential facts Maximum five. If you want a sixth, one of these was not essential.

- 1 Herzberg's hygiene factors cause dissatisfaction when absent but do not motivate when present.
- 2 Maslow claims strict prepotency; Alderfer's ERG explicitly allows regression.
- 3 Expectancy theory is multiplicative — any term at zero gives zero motivation.
- 4 Equity theory is about a ratio comparison, not about absolute reward.
- 5 McClelland's needs are learned, not innate.

Content and process theories of motivation

Content and process theories of motivation — Exam Matrix					
Theory	 DIST Family	Core claim	 EVD Scenario cue	 EXC What it does NOT claim	 TRAP Exam trap
Maslow Hierarchy of needs	Content	Needs are satisfied in a fixed ascending order	"...only became interested in recognition once job security improved"	Does not allow moving back down the hierarchy	Scenarios showing regression point to ERG, not Maslow
Alderfer ERG	Content	Existence, relatedness, growth — with a frustration-regression path	"...blocked from promotion, the employee refocused on team relationships"	Does not require needs to be met in order	Chosen only when regression is described; otherwise Maslow
Herzberg Two-factor	Content	Satisfaction and dissatisfaction have different causes	"...pay was fixed, but staff still reported no sense of achievement"	Does not claim hygiene factors motivate when improved	Treating the two factors as opposite ends of one scale
McClelland Acquired needs	Content	Achievement, affiliation and power needs, learned through experience	"...consistently chooses moderately difficult targets"	Does not claim the needs are universal or innate	Described as innate rather than acquired
Vroom Expectancy	Process	Motivation = Expectancy × Instrumentality × Valence	"...believed the effort was possible but doubted the bonus would follow"	Does not treat the terms as additive	Additive phrasing in the stem makes the option wrong
Adams Equity	Process	People compare their input/outcome ratio with a referent	"...was satisfied until learning what a peer earned"	Does not predict from absolute reward level alone	Confused with expectancy when a reward is mentioned at all

CORE core DIST  distinction EXC  exception TRAP  trap UPD  update EVD  evidence

DETAIL I ADDED MYSELF

Content and process theories of motivation

Decisive distinction

If an examiner forced me to separate these using ONE criterion, what would it be?

Whether the theory names the contents of motivation (which needs) or the reasoning that produces it (how the person evaluates effort and reward). Content theories answer "what", process theories answer "how".

Confusion pairs

A	B	Why confused	Decisive clue
Maslow	Alderfer (ERG)	Both are ascending need hierarchies with overlapping categories.	Any description of moving *back down* after frustration is ERG. Maslow forbids it.
Herzberg hygiene	Herzberg motivator	Both are called "factors" and both affect how people feel about work.	If removing it causes complaints but adding it causes nothing, it is hygiene.
Vroom	Adams	Both are process theories and both mention reward.	A comparison with another person is Adams. A judgement about one's own effort chain is Vroom.

Exception & trap matrix Only facts that can change an answer choice.

Statement / cue	Usually true	Exception	Why it tricks people	Source
■ Improving pay and working conditions will increase motivation.	False, in Herzberg terms	It removes dissatisfaction; motivation requires achievement, recognition, responsibility	Everyday usage treats "satisfied" and "motivated" as the same thing.	Reading list ch. 4
■ A person must satisfy lower needs before higher ones become active.	True for Maslow	Not for ERG, which permits simultaneous activation and regression	The stem rarely names the theorist — you must infer it from the cue.	Reading list ch. 4
■ High valence alone produces high motivation.	False	Expectancy is multiplicative — zero expectancy gives zero motivation	Wanting the reward feels sufficient, so the other two terms are ignored.	Reading list ch. 4

Question & evidence links

Matrix cell	Source	Exam / year	Question	Tested as	Error risk
Herzberg · What it does NOT claim	Reading list ch. 4	Sample 2024	Q12	"...the absence of hygiene factors causes dissatisfaction"	High
Vroom · Core claim	Reading list ch. 4	Sample 2022	Q31	"...the product of expectancy, instrumentality and valence"	Mid

Reliability and validity

Key comparison axis: Consistency vs correctness

WHY IT MATTERS

The two words are near-synonyms in ordinary English and technical opposites in psychometrics. Almost every candidate loses at least one mark here.

CORE QUESTION

Is the instrument consistent, or is it measuring the right thing?

PREREQUISITES Correlation coefficient **SOURCE** Reading list ch. 9

One-sentence model

Explain this topic in ONE sentence, as if to someone sitting the exam tomorrow. If you cannot, you do not know it yet.

Reliability is consistency of measurement and validity is whether the thing measured is the thing intended; a test can be perfectly reliable and completely invalid, but never valid without being reliable.

Five essential facts Maximum five. If you want a sixth, one of these was not essential.

- 1 Reliability is necessary but not sufficient for validity.
- 2 Test-retest reliability is threatened by practice effects.
- 3 Face validity is about appearance and carries no statistical weight.
- 4 Construct validity is established over many studies, not by one coefficient.
- 5 Increasing test length generally raises reliability.

Reliability and validity

Reliability and validity — Exam Matrix				
Concept	 DIST Question it answers	How it is evidenced	 EXC Main threat	 TRAP Exam trap
Test-retest reliability	Is it stable over time?	Correlation between two administrations	Practice and memory effects inflate it	Interval length is rarely stated but changes the interpretation
Internal consistency	Do the items hang together?	Cronbach's alpha, split-half	Alpha rises with test length even without improvement	Reading high alpha as evidence of unidimensionality
Inter-rater reliability	Do different raters agree?	Cohen's kappa, correlation between raters	Rater drift over a long scoring session	Confused with parallel-forms reliability
Content validity	Does it cover the whole domain?	Expert judgement against a specification	An incomplete domain specification	Confused with face validity, which is about appearance only
Criterion validity	Does it predict the outcome?	Correlation with an external criterion	Range restriction attenuates the coefficient	Predictive and concurrent differ only in timing
Construct validity	Does it measure the intended construct?	Convergent and discriminant evidence, accumulated	A poorly defined construct	Expecting a single number — it is a body of evidence

CORE core DIST  distinction EXC  exception TRAP  trap UPD  update EVD  evidence

DETAIL | ADDED MYSELF

Reliability and validity

Decisive distinction

If an examiner forced me to separate these using ONE criterion, what would it be?

Reliability asks whether repeated measurement agrees with itself. Validity asks whether it agrees with reality. Only validity requires anything outside the test.

Confusion pairs

A	B	Why confused	Decisive clue
Reliability	Validity	In ordinary English both mean roughly "trustworthy".	If the evidence comes from inside the test alone, it is reliability.
Face validity	Content validity	Both concern whether the test "looks right".	Face validity is judged by the test-taker; content validity by experts against a specification.

Exception & trap matrix Only facts that can change an answer choice.

Statement / cue	Usually true	Exception	Why it tricks people	Source
■ A highly reliable test is a good test.	Incomplete	A reliable test can measure the wrong construct with perfect consistency	Reliability is easy to quantify, so it becomes a proxy for quality.	Reading list ch. 9
■ Cronbach's alpha above 0.9 indicates an excellent scale.	Often stated	Very high alpha can indicate redundant items rather than quality	Higher is assumed better without a ceiling.	Reading list ch. 9

Question & evidence links

Matrix cell	Source	Exam / year	Question	Tested as	Error risk
Construct validity · How it is evidenced	Reading list ch. 9	Sample 2025	Q8	"...convergent and discriminant evidence"	High

Error log

Every conceptual mistake must name the matrix cell it invalidates.

Date	Question	Topic	My answer	Correct	Error type	Missing distinction	Matrix update	Retest
2026-08-05	Sample 2024 Q12	Motivation	Motivators	Hygiene factors	Wording misread	Absence causing dissatisfaction is the hygiene signature	Content and process theories of motivation · Herzberg · What it does NOT claim	2026-08-19
2026-08-06	Sample 2025 Q8	Psychometrics	Criterion validity	Construct validity	Confused pair	Convergent/discriminant evidence belongs to construct validity	Reliability and validity · Construct validity · How it is evidenced	2026-08-20

· Knowledge gap · Confused pair · Exception forgotten · Wording misread · Formula selection · Calculation error · Procedure order · Outdated information · Careless · Time pressure

Compression ladder

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L1

Full Matrix

Every distinction, every exception, every source.

L2

Exam-day Matrix

High-yield distinctions, exceptions, formulas, traps.

L3

Last 10 minutes

One page. What you would forget under pressure.

Exam-day matrix — L2

Markers	Topic	Decisive clue
◆ DIST	Content vs process	What motivation is made of vs how it is reasoned about.
◆ DIST	Regression	ERG allows it. Maslow does not.
■ TRAP	Herzberg asymmetry	Hygiene removes dissatisfaction. It does not motivate.
■ TRAP	Expectancy	Multiplicative. One zero term zeroes the whole thing.
◆ DIST	Reliability and validity	Reliable but invalid is possible. Valid but unreliable is not.
■ TRAP	Construct validity	A body of evidence, never a single coefficient.

Last-10-minutes sheet — L3

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|---|--|
| ☐ Regression described - ERG | ☐ McClelland - learned, not innate |
| ☐ Comparison with a peer - Adams | ☐ Reliable can be invalid |
| ☐ Own effort chain - Vroom | ☐ Valid cannot be unreliable |
| ☐ Hygiene removes dissatisfaction only | ☐ Face validity - appearance, no weight |
| ☐ Expectancy is multiplicative | ☐ Construct validity - accumulated evidence |

Review tracker Dates or ticks. Keep it secondary to the content.

Topic	Learned	R1	R2	R3	Mastered	Revisit
01 Content and process theories of motivation						
02 Reliability and validity						